No Men Are Foreign

The big idea

James Kirkup reminds us that **no men are strange and no countries foreign**. All human beings share the same body, the same earth and the same needs. War and hatred against others are really hatred against **ourselves**. The poem is a plea for **universal brotherhood** and **peace**.

Summary

- **Stanza 1**: Beneath all **uniforms**, a single body breathes like ours. The land our brothers walk on is the **same earth** in which we all shall lie (be buried).
- **Stanza 2**: They too are aware of **sun and air and water**, and are fed by peaceful harvests or starved by war's long winter. Their hands are like ours, and in their lines we read a labour not different from our own.
- **Stanza 3**: Their eyes, like ours, sleep and wake; there is strength that can be won by **love**. In every land there is a common life that all can recognise and understand.
- **Stanza 4**: Whenever we are told to **hate our brothers**, it is **ourselves** we shall dispossess, betray and condemn. When we take up arms against each other, it is **our own earth we defile**. Our **hells of fire and dust outrage the innocence of air** that is everywhere our own.

CENTRAL IDEA

Differences of nationality, religion and uniform are superficial. We are all one human family; war harms everyone, including the aggressor.

Poetic devices

Device	Example
Repetition	"Remember...", "Let us remember" (beginning and end)
Metaphor	"war's long winter" (hardship); "hells of fire and dust" (destruction)
Synecdoche	"uniforms" stands for soldiers/countries
Alliteration	"**w**ar's long **w**inter"; "**s**un and air"
Personification	"innocence of air"
Free verse	no regular rhyme scheme

Themes and values

- **Universal brotherhood** and equality.
- **Anti-war** message: war pollutes the earth and air we share.
- **Common humanity**: same labour, hands, eyes, earth.

"WE SHALL LIE" IS NOT ABOUT LYING

"The same earth... in which we all shall lie" means we are all **buried** in the same earth after death.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

How does the poet prove that no men are foreign? What happens when we hate our brothers? What is meant by "war's long winter"? Explain "hells of fire and dust".

Quick recap

- Same body, earth, sun, air, water, labour, eyes.
- Hating others = harming ourselves; war pollutes our own earth.

- Message: peace and brotherhood.

Practice questions

1. Who wrote "No Men Are Foreign"?
   (a) Robert Frost (b) James Kirkup (c) W. B. Yeats (d) Subramania Bharati
2. "Beneath all uniforms" refers to
   (a) school children (b) soldiers and people of different nations (c) doctors and nurses (d) sportspersons
3. "War's long winter" suggests
   (a) a cold season in war zones (b) the hardship and starvation caused by war (c) a holiday during war (d) a peace treaty
4. When we hate our brothers, according to the poet, we
   (a) become powerful (b) protect our country (c) betray and condemn ourselves (d) earn respect
5. "Our hells of fire and dust outrage the innocence of air" refers to
   (a) volcanic eruptions (b) forest fires (c) the pollution and destruction caused by war (d) a desert storm
6. The poem is written in
   (a) ABAB rhyme (b) ballad form (c) sonnet form (d) free verse
7. How does the poet prove that "no men are foreign"?

Answers: 1. b 2. b 3. b 4. c 5. c 6. d 7. see notes